

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 318

By Shaw

A RESOLUTION relative to naming the new entrance to the
Motlow Tunnel at the Tennessee State Capitol.

WHEREAS, the cornerstone for the Tennessee State Capitol was laid on July 4, 1845,
and construction on the building was finished in 1859; and

WHEREAS, this graceful structure was designed by noted architect William Strickland in
the Greek-temple style to symbolize strength and wisdom; and

WHEREAS, the crowning achievement of Mr. Strickland's career, the Tennessee State
Capitol not only gives an impression of permanence but also reassures us of the State's sound
governance; and

WHEREAS, adhering to the strictest economy, the Tennessee Capitol Building
Commission mandated that the State Capitol be built from solid limestone quarried directly from
the construction site; and

WHEREAS, as a cost-saving measure, the General Assembly authorized the use of
prison labor to quarry the limestone; among these prisoners, as many as ten were classified as
"good stonecutters" and another twenty "had some experience in the business"; and

WHEREAS, fifteen enslaved African Americans were rented by the State government to
quarry limestone at the State Capitol site; twelve names of these fifteen individuals have been
ascertained through historical record: Lewis, Daniel, Robert, Nelson, John, Parker, Dang, Bill,
John G., John, Andrew, and Jim; and

WHEREAS, these enslaved men were also involved in carving out the State Capitol's
cellar to exact specifications; for their skilled labor, A.G. Payne was paid \$18 per month, per
enslaved person; and

WHEREAS, while much of the quarry work could be done by prisoners and other unskilled labor, the setting and masonry work required the services of skilled artisans; and

WHEREAS, a small number of the skilled immigrant stonemasons (twelve Irishmen, five Germans, and one Frenchman) who had worked on the North Carolina State House under David Paton were hired for the decorative carving work; and

WHEREAS, a docket dated July 10, 1854, reveals that among the fifty-two stonecutters who worked on the State Capitol, five men (Martin Moor, Arch Young, Ivy, Duke, and Spencer) were identified as "Negro"; the list also included eight stonecutters who had traditionally Irish names (Donahoo, McCartney, O'Bryen (2), Casteel, Mccarns, Kelley, and Doolin), five with German or Prussian names (Rupp, Prusfininskey, Burk, Lazenbury, and Raby), and seventeen men whose origins were likely in the British Isles (Griffin, Harrison, Cash, Yates, Kind, Goad, Grooms, Miller, Howard, Philips, Jones, Mills, Black, Dyer, Mitchel, Avery, and Webb); and

WHEREAS, the prisoners, enslaved African Americans, artisans, stonemasons, stonecutters, and others who helped build the State Capitol made a significant contribution to this State that Tennesseans will always value; and

WHEREAS, for far too long, these individuals have not been given proper recognition for their labor, and we now wish to honor these men of different heritages, but one mission, for their work in building Tennessee's most treasured landmark; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we urge the Governor and the State Capitol Commission to designate the new entrance to the Motlow Tunnel as the "Heritage Gateway Entrance" in honor of the workers who helped build the Tennessee State Capitol.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that it is the sense of this General Assembly that these workers should be honored by the placement or erection of a monument or plaque at the new

entrance to the Motlow Tunnel and that this monument or plaque should include a list of all the known names of these individuals.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we urge the Governor to consult with the State Capitol Commission to identify funding for such monument or plaque.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that a certified copy of this resolution be transmitted to the Honorable Bill Lee, Governor of Tennessee, and the State Capitol Commission.